

What else to watch: *Metropolis* (1927, pp.32–33) ■ *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968, pp.192–93) ■ *Brazil* (1985, p.340) ■ *Ghost in the Shell* (1995) ■ *Gattaca* (1997)



Genetic designer J. F. Sebastian (William Sanderson, left) helps Pris (Daryl Hannah) to reach Tyrell. He has a premature-aging disease that makes replicants sympathetic to him.

teeming night markets like those of Tokyo in the 1980s; the mean streets of postwar pulp detective fiction; the crumbling architecture of 19th-century Los Angeles. The flying cars offer viewers a futuristic glimpse, but they are piloted by militaristic beat cops—symbols of fear rather than progress.

Dystopian vision

For moviegoers more used to the escapism of *Star Wars* (1977), Scott's vision of a mashed-up near-future is disorienting. In its depiction of people's relationship with new technologies, the movie retains its power to unnerve.

In *Blade Runner*, the future is a place in which humans and machines have become all but indistinguishable. Robotics, voice-activated computer systems, bionic implants, artificial intelligence, and genetic programming are part of the culture, and all controlled by faceless corporate mega-entities. In this dehumanized age, people are forced to take a polygraph-like exam (the "Voight-Kampff test") to prove that they are human.

The replicants are the ultimate product of this bleakly mechanized human society. They look and act like people, but they are not people. They have limited lifespans—four years in Batty's case—and are bred "off-world," forbidden to visit Earth. Deckard believes these unfortunate creatures are nothing more than automatons—until he falls in love with Rachael during his hunt for »



Ridley Scott Director

Ridley Scott is a British director, born in 1937, whose movies combine cool visual style with dynamic storytelling and crowd-pleasing Hollywood chutzpah. His debut feature, *The Duellists*, was swiftly followed by science-fiction horror *Alien* and the futuristic dystopia *Blade Runner*, two classics of modern cinema. Through the 1980s, Scott established himself as a hard-working filmmaker, but it was not until the 1991 mold-breaking female road-movie *Thelma & Louise* that he came close to matching the success of his science-fiction double act. A decade later he hit big once more, going back in time with the Roman epic *Gladiator*. In 2001, Scott directed the war movie, *Black Hawk Down*, based on a US raid on Mogadishu. He returned to science fiction in 2012 with the *Alien* prequel *Prometheus*.

Key movies

1977 *The Duellists*
1979 *Alien*
1982 *Blade Runner*
1991 *Thelma & Louise*
2000 *Gladiator*

“It’s not an easy thing to meet your maker.”

Roy Batty / Blade Runner